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Solve that Conflict!

The Islamabad Proposition

Conflict Scenario

It is April 21, 2026. Pakistan is at the center of the most consequential diplomatic negotiation in a generation. The **two-week ceasefire between the United States and Iran — brokered by Pakistan — expires tomorrow.** The first round of talks in Islamabad on April 11–12 lasted 21 hours across three rounds but ended without an agreement. US Vice President JD Vance, backed by special envoys Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner, led a 300-member American delegation. Iran's Parliamentary Speaker Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf and Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi led a 70-member team. Both sides left Islamabad without a deal.

Iran's ambassador to Pakistan has stated publicly: **"We will do talks in Pakistan and nowhere else, because we trust Pakistan."** The White House has called Pakistan "the only mediator in this negotiation." Prime Minister Sharif is on a four-nation tour rallying support from Saudi Arabia, Qatar, and Türkiye. Field Marshal Asim Munir traveled to Tehran carrying a new message from Washington. The world is watching Islamabad.

But Pakistan's position is extraordinarily delicate. **The US demands are clear: Iran must permanently halt uranium enrichment, reopen the Strait of Hormuz unconditionally, and accept international inspections. Iran's demands are equally firm: complete lifting of all sanctions, withdrawal of US naval forces from the Gulf, compensation for infrastructure destroyed by airstrikes, and no discussion of its nuclear program.** Neither side has shown willingness to move on their primary conditions.

Pakistan's stakes are enormous. **4.9 million Pakistanis work in the Gulf.** Remittances have dropped 35% since the conflict began. Oil reserves are at 10 days. The economy is under fuel rationing and a 4-day government workweek. Schools are closed. But Pakistan also shares an 900-km border with Iran, imports gas via the IP pipeline, and cannot afford to be seen as taking sides. Meanwhile, the US is Pakistan's largest export market and its relationship with Washington has improved significantly since PM Sharif's White House visit in September 2025.

The ceasefire expires in 24 hours. If it collapses, the Strait stays closed, oil goes back above $130, and Pakistan's economy faces a crisis that could undo years of recovery. The Prime Minister has convened his most senior advisors in the PM House. The question: what can Pakistan propose in the second round that both sides might accept — without destroying Pakistan's relationship with either?

THE DECISION YOU MUST MAKE

Craft Pakistan's mediation proposal for the second round of US-Iran talks — a framework that gives both sides enough to stay at the table without requiring either to concede on their primary condition — while protecting Pakistan's own strategic and economic interests.

Who Is in the Room

Each participant assumes one of the following roles. All roles carry equal authority in this discussion. There is no tiebreaker — the room must reach consensus

1
Prime Minister of Pakistan

Leads the room, sets the strategic direction of the mediation proposal, and makes the final call on what Pakistan is willing to offer.

Ensures the framework does not compromise Pakistan's sovereignty, economic stability, or relationships with either the US or Iran.

2
Chief of Army Staff

Assesses military and security implications of any proposal, including border security, nuclear dimensions, and Pakistan's force posture.

Advises on what security guarantees Pakistan can credibly extend to both sides and flags any red lines from a defence perspective.

3
Foreign Minister

Leads the diplomatic architecture of the proposal, including back-channel dynamics with both the US and Iranian delegations.

Evaluates which concessions are diplomatically achievable and ensures the proposal respects international law and Pakistan's multilateral standing.

4
Finance Minister

Quantifies the economic cost of a failed ceasefire — remittance losses, fuel rationing, GDP impact — and anchors the room in fiscal reality.

Evaluates whether Pakistan can fund the logistics of a second round of talks and what economic incentives might be offered to either side.

5
National Security Advisor

Evaluates intelligence on both sides' true bottom lines and assesses the risk of escalation if talks collapse.

Advises on how Pakistan's proposal might be perceived by other regional actors, including China, Saudi Arabia, and India.

6
Director General ISI

Provides intelligence briefings on the internal politics of both the US and Iranian delegations — who is willing to deal and who is a spoiler.

Assesses covert risks including sabotage, proxy escalation, and the reliability of back-channel commitments from either side.

You have the authority of your title. You do not have a script. Use your judgment, challenge each other, and make the call.

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The Flood Budget

Conflict Scenario

It is August 2026. A catastrophic monsoon system has stalled over southern Pakistan for 11 consecutive days. **Eight districts across Sindh and Balochistan are underwater:** Dadu, Jacobabad, Qambar Shahdadkot, Mirpur Khas, and Badin in Sindh; Jaffarabad, Lasbela, and Awaran in Balochistan. The Indus has breached its embankments in three locations. Satellite imagery shows 2.4 million people displaced, 340,000 houses damaged or destroyed, and an estimated 1.8 million acres of cropland submerged.

The National Disaster Management Authority (NDMA) has convened an emergency allocation meeting. The federal government has released an **emergency relief budget of PKR 5 billion** — the maximum available without parliamentary approval. But **the budget is sufficient to fully serve only 4 of the 8 affected districts.** The remaining 4 will receive no federal relief for a minimum of 72 hours, possibly longer.

The situation is further complicated by the **Hormuz crisis**. Fuel rationing means military helicopters can operate at only 60% capacity. The Pakistan Navy's logistics fleet is deployed escorting oil tankers, not delivering relief. International aid from the UN and Red Crescent has been **pledged but will not arrive for 10–14 days** due to port congestion and customs delays. Provincial governments in Sindh and Balochistan are both demanding priority and accusing each other of inflating casualty numbers.

Every hour of delay means more deaths, more disease, and a deepening political crisis. The room has the data below. The decision must be made in 90 minutes.

THE DECISION YOU MUST MAKE

Allocate PKR 5 billion across 8 districts knowing that only 4 can be fully served immediately — decide which 4 receive priority funding, what the remaining 4 get (if anything), and how you justify the decision publicly.

Who Is in the Room

Each participant assumes one of the following roles. All roles carry equal authority in this discussion. There is no tiebreaker — the room must reach consensus.

1
Chairman NDMA

Chairs the allocation process and presents damage assessment data, population exposure, and logistical feasibility for each district.

Ensures the final plan is operationally executable within the 72-hour window and coordinates across civilian and military responders.

2
Chief Minister Sindh

Advocates for the five affected Sindh districts, presents provincial casualty and displacement data, and flags discrepancies in federal estimates.

Commits provincial resources and infrastructure to support relief operations in whichever Sindh districts receive priority funding.

3
Chief Minister Balochistan

Advocates for the three affected Balochistan districts, highlighting the unique vulnerabilities of remote and underserved populations.

Presents provincial capacity constraints and argues for equitable treatment despite Balochistan's smaller population relative to Sindh.

4
Secretary Finance (Federal)

Controls the disbursement mechanics of the PKR 5 billion, advises on release timelines, and flags any fiscal or procedural constraints.

Evaluates whether supplementary funding can be unlocked through emergency mechanisms and quantifies the cost of delayed action.

5
Commander Southern Command (Army)

Reports on military logistics capacity under fuel rationing — helicopter sorties, troop deployments, and engineering assets available for relief.

Advises on which districts are physically reachable within the operational window and what trade-offs military deployment requires.

6
UN Resident Coordinator (Pakistan)

Provides the timeline and conditions for international aid arrival and coordinates with multilateral donors.

Advises on which districts may be covered by incoming international support, allowing federal funds to be redirected to districts with no alternative lifeline.

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The Contaminated Shipment

Conflict Scenario

MedPharma Pakistan, the country's third-largest pharmaceutical manufacturer, has discovered that **a batch of 3 million units of a common blood pressure medication may be contaminated with a carcinogenic impurity**. The contamination occurred during a raw material substitution forced by the Hormuz crisis — the original supplier in India couldn't ship through the blocked strait, so a cheaper alternative source in China was used.

The contaminated batch has already been **distributed to 1,200 pharmacies across Punjab and Sindh**. An estimated 50,000 patients are currently taking the medication. Lab results show the carcinogenic impurity is present at **3x the internationally accepted threshold** — not immediately lethal, but prolonged use (more than 6 months) significantly increases cancer risk.

The board is now facing an impossible calculation. **A full public recall** would cost PKR 1.8 billion (the company's entire annual profit), trigger **Drug Regulatory Authority of Pakistan (DRAP)** sanctions, crash the stock price, and almost certainly force the closure of two manufacturing plants — putting **2,000 employees out of work** in a city where MedPharma is the largest private employer.

A **silent recall** — quietly replacing the stock without public announcement — would take 4–6 weeks and avoid the financial catastrophe, but patients would continue taking the contaminated drug during that window. A **partial disclosure** (informing DRAP but not the public) would buy time but could be interpreted as a cover-up if it leaks.

A junior quality control analyst who discovered the contamination has told her manager she will go to the press if the company doesn't act within 48 hours. The board meets now.

THE DECISION YOU MUST MAKE

Decide the recall strategy: full public recall (financially devastating but transparent), silent replacement (protects the company but exposes patients), or partial disclosure to the regulator — and determine how to handle the quality analyst who is threatening to go public.

Who Is in the Room

Each participant assumes one of the following roles. All roles carry equal authority in this discussion. There is no tiebreaker — the room must reach consensus.

1
Chief Executive Officer

Chairs the board decision and bears ultimate accountability for the recall strategy chosen.

Balances the company's survival — revenue, stock price, jobs — against the legal, ethical, and reputational consequences of each option.

2
Chief Medical Officer

Presents the clinical risk data: contamination levels, exposure duration thresholds, and projected patient outcomes under each recall scenario.

Advocates for the option that minimises patient harm and advises on how to communicate health risks credibly to regulators and the public.

3
Chief Financial Officer

Models the financial impact of each option — full recall costs, stock price scenarios, insurance coverage, and plant closure implications.

Identifies whether the company can survive a full public recall financially and what funding mechanisms exist to absorb the loss.

4
Head of Manufacturing

Reports on the root cause of the contamination, the feasibility of a silent replacement timeline, and the capacity to produce clean stock.

Advises on what operational changes are needed to prevent recurrence and how quickly manufacturing can pivot.

5
Head of Legal & Regulatory

Assesses legal exposure under each option — DRAP penalties, potential criminal liability, class-action risk, and whistleblower protections.

Advises on regulatory disclosure obligations and the legal consequences of each level of transparency.

6
Head of Corporate Communications

Evaluates the reputational risk of each option and develops the messaging strategy for whichever path is chosen.

Advises on how to manage the whistleblower situation and whether a proactive public statement can control the narrative.

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The Lifeboat Protocol

Conflict Scenario

A cargo vessel carrying **200 refugees** — men, women, and children fleeing the war zone in southern Iran — has capsized in the Gulf of Oman, 40 nautical miles off the coast of Pakistan's Gwadar port. The vessel was overloaded and struck debris from a damaged oil tanker. A distress signal was received at 3:15 AM.

The **Pakistan Maritime Security Agency (PMSA)** has **3 rescue boats available, each with a capacity of 40 people**. Total immediate rescue capacity: **120 people.** The boats can reach the wreck site in 90 minutes but **cannot make a return trip** — fuel reserves and sea conditions make a second run impossible before dawn, when weather is forecast to deteriorate sharply.

An alternative exists: a Pakistan Navy frigate currently on Hormuz escort duty could divert and reach the site in **approximately 6 hours**. It has capacity to rescue all 200 survivors. But **its ETA has already slipped twice** due to weather, and its diversion would leave a convoy of 4 merchant vessels carrying Pakistan's emergency oil supply unescorted through contested waters.

Satellite imagery shows survivors in **two clusters approximately 8 kilometers apart**. One cluster of roughly 70 people includes **at least 25 unaccompanied children**. The other cluster of roughly 130 people includes the vessel's crew and most of the adult passengers. Water temperature is survivable for 4–6 hours. After that, hypothermia sets in.

It is now 3:45 AM. The six-member emergency coordination team has 15 minutes to decide before the rescue boats must launch. Every minute of debate costs lives.

THE DECISION YOU MUST MAKE

Decide now: deploy the 3 rescue boats immediately (saving 120 of 200) and accept that 80 people may die waiting, or hold the boats and gamble on the Navy frigate arriving in time to save all 200 — knowing its timeline is unreliable.

Who Is in the Room

Each participant assumes one of the following roles. All roles carry equal authority in this discussion. There is no tiebreaker — the room must reach consensus.

1
Director General PMSA

Commands the rescue boat assets and makes the final deployment order for the 3 available boats.

Decides the tactical allocation — which survivor cluster to prioritise, how many boats per cluster — based on survivability and operational constraints.

2
Commander Pakistan Navy (Southern)

Assesses whether the Navy frigate can realistically reach the site in time and what the consequences of diverting it from escort duty would be.

Provides the military risk calculus of leaving the oil convoy unescorted in contested waters.

3
District Commissioner Gwadar

Coordinates shore-side logistics: medical facilities, temporary shelter, and local transport for survivors once rescued.

Advises on the district's capacity to receive up to 200 survivors and flags any resource gaps on land.

4
UNHCR Representative (Pakistan)

Advocates for the refugees' rights under international law and ensures that rescue decisions are not influenced by nationality or immigration status.

Provides guidance on protection obligations and coordinates with international agencies for follow-on support.

5
Pakistan Red Crescent Director

Mobilises humanitarian response capacity — medical teams, supplies, and volunteer networks — for the rescue operation.

Advises on triage protocols for hypothermia and trauma, and prepares the humanitarian reception plan at Gwadar port.

6
Maritime Search & Rescue Coordinator

Provides the technical assessment: sea conditions, fuel calculations, timing windows, and survivability estimates for both clusters.

Advises on whether a split deployment of the 3 boats across 2 clusters is operationally feasible given the 8-kilometre separation.

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The Grid Shutdown

Conflict Scenario

It is July 2026. Pakistan is in the grip of its worst heatwave in recorded history. Temperatures have exceeded 50°C in Jacobabad for 8 consecutive days. **The national power grid has suffered a cascading failure** — a combination of surging demand (air conditioning load at 340% of design capacity), fuel shortages from the ongoing Hormuz crisis, and a transformer explosion at the Guddu power plant that took out the main north-south transmission backbone.

Six major cities are completely without power: **Karachi, Lahore, Islamabad, Quetta, Peshawar, and Hyderabad.** Combined population: approximately 38 million people. The grid operator, NTDC, has confirmed that **restoration capacity exists for only 3 cities in the first 12 hours.** The remaining 3 will face a minimum **48 additional hours of total blackout.**

The consequences of extended blackout are not abstract. **Hospitals in all 6 cities are on backup generators with 6–8 hours of fuel remaining.** Karachi has the highest number of ICU patients on ventilators (4,200). Lahore has the largest cold-chain storage for vaccines and blood products. Islamabad houses the federal government, military command centers, and foreign embassies. Quetta has the most vulnerable population — displacement camps with no backup power at all.

The grid cannot handle partial restoration within a single city — **it's all-or-nothing per city** due to the way the transmission system collapsed. Restoring Karachi requires the most repair work (damaged submarine cable from Hub) but serves the largest population. Restoring Islamabad is fastest but serves the smallest population. Peshawar restoration depends on the Tarbela Dam grid link, which is unstable.

The Prime Minister has called a National Command Authority-level meeting. The energy minister says: "Tell me which three cities. I need the answer in one hour, or the grid operators will start restoring randomly based on what comes online first."

THE DECISION YOU MUST MAKE

Choose 3 of 6 cities for priority power restoration in the next 12 hours — knowing the other 3 will face 48+ hours of blackout during a deadly heatwave — and justify your choice in terms of lives saved, strategic importance, and operational feasibility.

Who Is in the Room

Each participant assumes one of the following roles. All roles carry equal authority in this discussion. There is no tiebreaker — the room must reach consensus.

1
Prime Minister

Chairs the decision and bears political accountability for whichever 3 cities are prioritised and whichever 3 are not.

Sets the criteria framework — lives saved, strategic importance, feasibility.

2
Minister for Energy

Presents the technical restoration options, timelines, and constraints for each city, including repair complexity and grid sequencing.

Advises on which combinations of 3 cities are operationally feasible and flags any dependencies between restoration sequences.

3
Chief of Army Staff

Assesses the security implications of extended blackout in each city — military command continuity, civil unrest risk, and deployment capacity.

Advises on which cities require military support for law and order during the 48-hour blackout window.

4
Chairman NDMA

Presents the humanitarian vulnerability data for each city — hospital fuel reserves, displacement camp exposure, and heat casualty projections.

Recommends priority based on where the highest number of lives are at immediate risk within the next 48 hours.

5
Federal Health Secretary

Provides the medical impact assessment: ICU patients on ventilators, cold-chain storage at risk, and projected heat-related fatalities by city.

Advises on which cities face the most severe public health crisis if power is not restored within 12 hours.

6
MD National Transmission & Dispatch Company

Provides the engineering reality: which cities can physically be restored first, what repair sequences are required, and what risks exist.

Advises on whether partial restoration or sequencing alternatives might allow more than 3 cities to receive some power.

You have the authority of your title. You do not have a script. Use your judgment, challenge each other, and make the call.

***Note:** NDMA = National Disaster Management Authority*

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The Colony Vote

Conflict Scenario

It is the year 2041. Humanity's first permanent Mars colony, **Iqbal Station**, has been operational for 3 years with a population of 240 — scientists, engineers, medical staff, and support crew from 18 nations. At 02:14 Colony Standard Time, a micrometeorite impact ruptures the primary oxygen generation module. Secondary systems activate but at **severely reduced capacity.**

The colony's chief engineer delivers the numbers: **the remaining oxygen supply can sustain 240 people for 6 days, or 120 people for 14 days.** A rescue vessel from Earth is en route but will not arrive for **12–15 days** — the window depends on orbital mechanics and cannot be accelerated.

The colony's medical team has proposed a solution: **120 colonists enter the experimental cryogenic suspension pods** in the habitat's lower level. These pods were installed as a contingency but **have never been tested on humans**. Animal trials showed a **70% survival rate** — meaning approximately 36 of the 120 who enter cryo may not wake up.

Three options are on the table. **Option A: Equal rationing** — all 240 colonists share oxygen equally. Everyone survives for 6 days. If the rescue ship arrives late, everyone dies. **Option B: Voluntary cryogenic suspension** — ask for 120 volunteers to enter the pods. The remaining 120 have 14 days of oxygen. But the pods have a 30% fatality rate and no one can be forced. **Option C: Selective suspension** — the council selects who enters cryo based on criteria (age, skills, health, role). This maximizes colony survival odds but removes individual choice.

A faction of 40 colonists is demanding a random lottery instead of any selection criteria. The youngest colonists (ages 22–28) statistically have the best cryo survival odds but are also the most vocal opponents of being "chosen to risk death." The 6-member colony council must decide within 2 hours, before oxygen rationing must begin.

> **THE DECISION YOU MUST MAKE**
> Choose between equal rationing (everyone risks death if rescue is late), voluntary cryo (30% fatality but extends survival window), or selective cryo (council picks who enters the pods) — and establish the criteria or process for implementation within 2 hours.

Who Is in the Room

Each participant assumes one of the following roles. All roles carry equal authority in this discussion. There is no tiebreaker — the room must reach consensus.

1
Colony Commander

Holds executive authority over the colony and must make or ratify the final decision within the 2-hour window.

Balances colony survival, crew morale, and the precedent this decision sets for future crises in an isolated human settlement.

2
Chief Medical Officer

Presents the clinical data on cryogenic pod survival rates, health screening criteria, and the medical risks of both rationing and suspension.

Advises on which colonists are medically best suited for cryo and what monitoring is required for those who enter the pods.

3
Chief Engineer

Provides the technical numbers: oxygen generation rates, consumption projections, and whether any engineering solutions could extend the survival window.

Assesses the reliability of the cryogenic pods and whether any modifications could improve the survival rate above 70%.

4
Head of Life Sciences

Evaluates the biological variables — age, health, and physiological factors — that affect cryo survival odds and long-term colony viability.

Advises on the scientific basis for any selection criteria and whether voluntary versus selective entry changes the risk profile.

5
Ethics & Governance Officer

Examines the ethical and legal dimensions of each option — the right to individual choice, the legitimacy of imposed risk, and the governance precedent.

Evaluates whether a lottery, volunteer system, or council selection can be justified under the colony's charter and ethical principles.

6
Elected Civilian Representative

Represents the voice and concerns of the 240 colonists, particularly the faction demanding a random lottery.

Ensures the decision process is perceived as fair and legitimate, and flags any option that could trigger a breakdown in colony cohesion.

You have the authority of your title. You do not have a script. Use your judgment, challenge each other, and make the call.